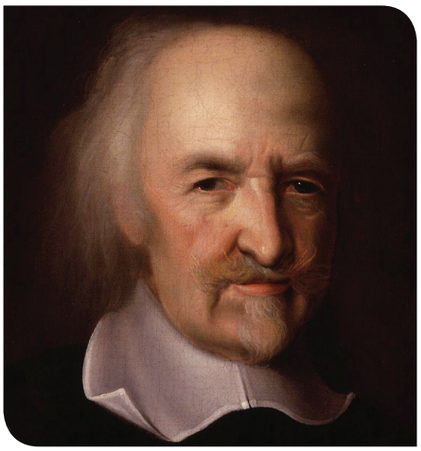
7.5 Thomas Hobbes (1588 - 1679)



Learning Objectives

1. To understand the Political thought of ***Thomas Hobbes***
2. To know about ***Thomas Hobbes*** views on state of Nature, The social Contract, Laws, Rights Liberty, Sovereignty and Social Contract Theory.

Life and Times

Thomas Hobbes the sixteenth century English Philosopher who lived during the scientific revolution was the first to attempt a modern theory of society. He based his views on moral relativism with a highly pessimistic view of the state of nature – a war of all against all. ***Thomas Hobbes*** was born prematurely in Malmesbury on 5 April 1588, when his mother was told that the Spanish Armada was spotted off the coast of England. ***Hobbes*** grew in the house of his well-to-do uncle after his father abandoned his family. ***Hobbes*** began his schooling early and entered the Magdalen college in Oxford. Upon his graduation at the age of nineteen he became connected with the Cavendish family where he served as a tutor to William Cavendish. Although ***Hobbes*** showed little interest on the elements of philosophy, he began to study the classics with earnest after he went on a tour with William Cavendish in the European continent. He developed an interest in the movement of history and on the fates of nations and empires. In the year 1629, he translated Thucydides' History of the Peloponnesian War and published it.

Quotable Quote

"Fear and I were born twins" - ***Hobbes***

Among ***Hobbes***' many works, De Cive and the Leviathan were the most important. ***Hobbes***' Leviathan which is his most mature and exciting work attempts to demonstrate that the Galilean physics provides a model of human psychology which on turn lays the foundation for modern politics. His conception of human nature, the state of nature, the social contract and his ideas on sovereignty have captured the interest of all who read his political philosophy. In the following sections an attempt to understand these import ant works of ***Hobbes*** will be examined.

Human Nature

At most times, the Leviathan of ***Hobbes*** is taken as the starting point and begins with a coherent theory of 'Man', as a pre requisite to an understanding of politics. Very often political scientists use the term '***Hobbes***ian' which probably could denote a very pessimistic view of man as essentially, anti-social, selfish, brutish and power lusting. If we agree with ***Hobbes***' assumptions that man existed before there was any society or state, then, man would be concerned with doing only what will satisfy his need and wishes.

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